To give formal shape to these agreements, on 17 January 1842 Shuja's son Prince Shahpur, Aminullah Khan Logari and Zaman Khan Barakzai attended court at the Bala Hisar fort, 'together with their banners and their horsemen and those of the khans of the Durranis, the Ghilzais, the Farsi-speakers of Kohistan and Kabul, to greet His Majesty and receive his orders'. Herati added, 'From then on, the same ritual was observed every morning and evening, and His Majesty kept these newly co-opted rebels busy with promises of position, stipends and monetary rewards. Meanwhile he wrote to George MacGregor and the British commanders in Jalalabad that the situation was finally coming under control.'[14]

By the end of the first week of February, despite all the disasters of the previous three months, it was becoming increasingly clear that the apparent victory of Akbar Khan was by no means a forgone conclusion, and that Shuja still had everything to play for. Indeed, in one of the strange revivals of fortune which marked Shuja's life, he was now arguably in more direct control of his ancestral lands than he had been at any other point in his reign. Seeing the way the winds were blowing, many of the remaining Durrani and Qizilbash chiefs now cast their lot with the Shah and one by one began coming to his durbar to offer their allegiance and beg his forgiveness. 'As the new alliances grew firm,' wrote Maulana Kashmiri, 'the Shah held court and granted audience to all the Khans.'

> He elevated all the high lords even higher
> And showered his benevolence upon the soldiery
>
> Kabul became free of violence and sedition
> Governance was once again the business of the Shah
>
> But he did not accord Akbar a place
> The hatred in his heart had not grown cold . . .[15]

The situation was still delicate. Shuja did not yet dare leave the Bala Hisar, and he remained dependent on the support of his two new allies, especially the muscle of Aminullah Khan. According to Mirza 'Ata, the Shah remained a little 'suspicious, as these two Kabul chiefs had once been partisans of Amir Dost Mohammad Khan: could they be plotting to take his life? And now the English were said to be approaching again, and could well attempt to re-conquer Khurasan. Shuja was between a rock and a hard place. Nevertheless the King had at that time some 10,000 troops, 12